

A Night at The Symphony

Xian Zhang is the center of attention, yet the audience cannot see her face. She swings her arms around, jumps up and down, and shuffles her feet, all within a two-foot square board. One moment, she is a firm general leading an army into battle. In another, she is released from command, content simply to be, shoulders loose and open, looking up to the ornate ceiling above her. Through it all, her right hand, holding a beautifully crafted rod, moves as clockwork. Zhang is conducting the Yale Philharmonia in Tchaikovsky's *Symphony no. 4* at Woolsey Hall, Yale University.

For forty-five minutes, Zhang is the heartbeat of the orchestra, the soul of the hall, the voice of Tchaikovsky himself. The musicians, one hundred of the best in the world, intently wait for her cues. Hundreds of people in the auditorium, who have paid their time and money, hope to witness one of the greatest works in Classical music. Pyotr Ilyich Tchaikovsky, who wrote the symphony during the darkest time in his life, tries to speak through the music. There is so much that Zhang must do, yet she cannot make the performance about herself.

The weight of the moment is enormous. The Yale Philharmonia is one of the premier music school orchestras in America. Built in 1902, Woolsey Hall is home to the Newberry Memorial Organ, one of the most renowned symphonic organs in the world. The venue, graced by a gold-trimmed cathedral ceiling with stunning images of the Nine Muses and Athena, has hosted hundreds of performances and events including some of the most influential figures in the world.

Tchaikovsky's *Symphony no. 4* was born out of a time of great despair. Tchaikovsky endured the end of a disastrous marriage and had attempted suicide. His fourth symphony became a breakthrough work that transcended the Russian symphonic

works written before him through its intensity and ambition. It is a statement on fate, despair, joy, and navigating all those forces.

Zhang is laser-focused. Her eyes constantly shift between the sheet music on the stand in front and the musicians surrounding her. Though conductor in name, Zhang is engaging in an athletic act. She goes through many motions. A slight crouch and hunched back signal a delicate passage to which everyone should pay more attention. Bouncing shoulders and toes suggest a playful sequence of notes. A completely swaying body tells everyone that this is the climax, the moment where all emotions are packed so tightly, so intensely and raw that we must place all of ourselves within these seconds to truly understand the music.

Though Tchaikovsky's *Symphony no. 4* has been performed innumerable times, this performance is different from the rest. Such is the nature of live music. Zhang must bring out all of Tchaikovsky's soul, from dire anguish to unbridled joy. Tchaikovsky died in 1893, yet she must understand his pain and allow the audience to feel it. Like the conductors before her, she must continue the conversation carried through the score. She must find a way to tell its story. She is both the audience and the performer, the receiver and the creator. She follows the notes yet controls the moment. She gives voice to a composer who can no longer speak for himself.

Through calculated movements, Zhang changes the complexion of the hall instantly. The orchestra carefully follows her lead. They catch onto the slightest changes in her mannerisms. Sometimes, she fiercely shakes her hand, asking more from them. Other times, she extends her palm, telling them to play quietly and be more attentive to the balance of the composition. With a mastery of the piece, she knows how to convey its meaning through the musicians. Though she is the only one on stage who makes no

sound, Zhang is the engine that runs the orchestra. The players move in sync with her. They are all dancers, providing music to their own movement.

A flurry of notes ascends as the piece approaches the end. A fanfare emerges within the commotion of strings and battering of percussion. Zhang both controls this storm and lets it grow. Her arms swing wider and faster, still meticulously keeping track of the tempo through her baton. She is now jumping, feet fully removed from the conducting podium.

Immediately after the orchestra finishes the final chord, the audience erupts in applause. For the first time, Zhang turns around. Her face is beaming with joy, sweat slowly falling along her face. The applause bursts. She bows, deservedly welcoming the praise. But she is then quick to direct the attention to the orchestra. She tells the musicians to rise and points out those who played solos. She knows this moment is for the players, whose sound brought the performance to life.

Tchaikovsky's reflections on his fourth symphony survive today through letters. Though facing so much despair himself, he still fought to find some kind of hope. "If within yourself you find no reasons for joy, then look at others. See how they can enjoy themselves, surrendering themselves wholeheartedly to joyful feelings," he wrote.

As Zhang looks at the orchestra and back at the audience, she sees only smiles. The hall is lifted by the triumphant joy left by the performance. Though in the middle of a brutal New England winter and burdened by the foresight of a ruthless snowstorm that will soon come, everyone leaves the concert hall with hope. This is what Zhang has imparted. An experience that they will never forget. Not a memory of her or the orchestra, but rather, of the feeling of joy that can come even in the darkest moments of life.